

THE HUNDRED CANDLES

A sheet for playing hyakumonogatari kaidankai with this book.

One of the five books Hearn names in his prefatory note is the Hyaku-Monogatari — the Hundred Tales. It is worth a page, because it is not a book. It is a game, and the genre of book is named after it.

Hyakumonogatari kaidankai, the hundred-tales gathering, was popular in the Edo period; the earliest record of it is in the Otogi Monogatari of 1660. A company lights a hundred lamps. Each person in turn tells a tale of the strange, and after each tale one lamp is put out. The room grows darker at a measurable rate — a rate the company can see coming — and when the hundredth lamp is snuffed, the thing the tales have been summoning is understood to be present in the dark with everyone.

The usual practice was to stop at ninety-nine.

The game produced a publishing genre. In 1677 the first kaidan-shū, the Shokoku Hyakumonogatari — Hundred Tales of Many Provinces — appeared, and later collections of the kind went on borrowing the name. So when Hearn says he took his tales from the Hyaku-Monogatari, he is naming a shelf rather than a volume, which is one more reason his sources cannot be reduced to a list of five books with a tale attached to each.

It also explains a quality of Kwaidan that puzzles readers who expect a novelist's shaping. These tales were built to be told aloud, one after another, by different voices, to people sitting in a room that was getting darker. They are short because a turn is short. They end abruptly because the next person is waiting. And the flat, unhurried, uninsistent tone that Hearn worked so hard for in English is the tone of somebody who knows the dark is doing the work for him.

How to play it with seventeen tales instead of a hundred

Light seventeen candles, or seventeen anything. Read a tale aloud; put one out. The room gets darker at a rate everyone can see coming, which is the whole mechanism. Stop at sixteen. That is not a joke about safety — leaving the last one lit is what the Edo companies did, and a game whose rule you keep is more frightening than one you finish.

An order that works

Short and hard first, so nobody settles; the two long ones in the middle, when attention is highest; the strange, quiet ones last, when the room is nearly dark.

#	Tale	Words
1	Oshidori	476
2	Mujina	592
3	Jiu-Roku-Zakura	477
4	Ubazakura	513
5	Diplomacy	721
6	A Dead Secret	899
7	Riki-Baka	666
8	The Story Of O-Tei	1,087
9	Hi-Mawari	757

#	Tale	Words
10	Of A Mirror And A Bell	1,640
11	Jikininki	1,681
12	Yuki-Onna	1,494
13	The Dream Of Akinosuké	2,005
14	The Story Of Aoyagi	3,030
15	Rokuro-Kubi	3,504
16	The Story Of Mimi-Nashi-Hōichi	3,286
17	Hōrai	1,080

From Kwaidan: Stories and Studies of Strange Things, Valice Classics 13. Free at valicepress.com/companion/kwaidan